The Dead Don’t Feast

And the living don’t rise. A dark fantasy WIP story inspired by the world of Minecraft.

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Ch0 - The Garden

She had picked a good spot.

The garden breathed, indifferent to the burden of the world as she plunged the shovel deeper into the earth.

Didn't it know that everything that breathes, in time, withers and dies? Didn't it care?

Alice ignored the sweat of her pale brow, dripping slowly onto wet soil as she kept on digging the hole. She moved efficiently as she threw dirt above her shoulder, careful not to stain her black jacket, gray tie and white gloves, all neatly folded together on the ground.

Her raven-black hair was tied behind her head with worn pink ribbons. The rest of her butler costume was loose for once, a white shirt with rolled-up sleeves paired with black pants and boots.

She breathed too. But the difference was, she knew what the garden denied.

She didn't breathe out of necessity. She did out of respect. For the person who couldn't anymore.

A sudden throbbing pain coursed through her left temple, making her pause in her task. The fleshy, deep and dark substance that replaced skin on the left part of her face pulsed under the moonlight.

Teal patterns shimmered with agony, grief taking swirling shapes across the dark matter that covered half her body underneath the suit. Darkness overtook her vision for a brief moment. Alice blinked, then found herself collapsed against the shovel, holding herself up with her good hand. She pinched the bridge of her nose with her left hand, trying to steady a ragged breath. The pulsing living matter coursing through her fingers brushed against soft skin.

The pain would pass. It always did.

It felt like it whispered an angry cacophony into her ears. She turned a deaf ear, clutching the shovel's handle hard enough to hurt.

After what felt like hours, the pain subsided enough for her to resume her work. She let out a shuddered breath, loosening her tight grip on the tool and plunged it back under the dirt again.

The witch had said not to push herself when these… 'waves of discomfort' came. She had said, quite sternly, to rest and wait it out in silence. So, even now, she did as such.

But she still had a job to do.

The garden breathed again. Echoes of the witch's words played over her mind.

The witch had said a lot of things. That she was a sweet girl. That she wasn't to go alone at night. That she didn't need a tool, but would have liked a friend.

The witch was a fool. How could she ever be more than a tool?

That she had never seen anything like it. That the darkness of the spots contrasted quite nicely next to the pale white of her complexion.

Even now, if a stranger came by, they might mistake her for a corpse digging its own grave.

They'd be wrong. She was digging the witch's.

The shovel hit rock.

Alice stopped her motion, pausing for a second. Her eyes, the right one blue and the left a dull gray, looked around the hole in the dark, judging its depth. Despite being in the shadow of a large tree, she could see just fine. She didn't need light.

She never did since then.

Once she deemed the hole satisfactory, Alice rose out from the earth with efficiency. Shovel in hand, she looked at the woman resting next to a bush of black roses.

The garden breathed. She did not.

For a moment, Alice didn't either.

Her expression stayed cold, her face made of marble despite the momentary breathlessness. She matched her expression.

"You have the resting face of a corpse, deary," the old woman had teased with a grin on her face, a few days ago. She was stirring her cauldron, the liquid inside pulsing with a thousand colors.

"... Have you ever seen me wear any other face, madam?" Alice had responded with a flat tone, handing her an ingredient.

The witch had then turned to her, the smile faltering into something wistful.

But the corpse before her would not smile anymore. In the end, her face had stilled into something solemn, dignified.

It was fitting, Alice thought. She had never seen the woman wear anything but a smile. And now, in death, she had shed it. Cast off mortality itself to testify of another kind of life. As if she dared the gods to bury her smile.

The garden breathed. Alice did too. The corpse did not.

Alice looked at the Moon. It was higher in the sky than she expected it to be, its soft glow reminiscent of *his* old nightlight. She frowned, slightly. It wasn't like her to take this long for a task she had already done dozens of times.

The cold air ruffled mangrove leaves. Fireflies buzzed in the distance, lighting up the night like stars in the sky.

She lifted the corpse up into her arms, gentle.

The garden breathed.

She deposited into the grave, standing up to take one last look at the witch.

She was peaceful.

How did it feel? To not exist?

To rest?

Alice turned away, grabbing her discarded shovel, careful not to step on her clothes folded on the ground. She pushed it back under the pile of dirt.

It wasn't her question to answer.

She breathed. The only ones who could, didn't.

Ch1 - The Request

Morning came as it usually did. Gentle as the touch of a mother.

The scent of wet soil filled the air as first light softly filtered through the curtains. The closed window muffled sounds from the outside: the rustle of leaves and vines in the wind, the early calls of various birds perched on the branches, the *splash* of a toad jumping from a lilypad.

Faint light spilled through the room, casting across her face. The new day made itself known by illuminating her closed eyes through a deliberate gap between the curtains.

Alice awoke in stages.

First, her left fist tightened its grip on the sheets. The pulsing matter serving as skin shifted as if pained by the sudden bright light. Then, a light frown appeared on her face, betraying a rare discomfort few believed she could have.

A low sound rumbled from under her skin, the familiar hum almost otherworldly. The dark substance that covered hand, arm, shoulder and half her face paused its swirls, as if listening to a song only *it* could hear. The patterns slowed, comforted by the deep melody. An angry fire on her skin reduced to embers, shifting slightly as it responded to the sunlight in acknowledgment.

Finally, Alice opened her eyes.

There was no emotion as consciousness came over. No glint of past dreams or nightmares. Just the state of existence once more burdened over her. And she would rise to face it once again.

Alice laid in bed for a few more moments, back against the mattress, staring emptily at the ceiling.

Dark wood planks stared back, the only thing of note there being a slight crack and a spider’s webbing.

She counted the seconds.

One. Two. Three. Four. A crow cawed outside her window.

Five. Six. Seven. The spiderweb shifted slightly, its maker waking up with the day.

Eight. Nine. Ten.

…

She was usually up by now.

She still lay in bed, unmoving, staring at the ceiling.

Eleven. Twelve.

Why was she still in bed? Shouldn't she be up by now?

Thirteen.

What was she waiting for?

Fourteen.

Something was missing.

Was it?

Yes. There should have been a familiar knocking on her door, accompanied by the soft voice of an old woman. Or even her cough, dirty and wet, coming from the room over.

Why couldn't she hear it?

Fifteen.

Right.

The witch was dead.

She wouldn't come to her in the morning anymore. She didn't need Alice anymore.

…

Sixteen.

Alice sat up, then stepped off the bed. She took a single breath as her feet touched the floor, feeling the way the dark matter flexed with her muscles. She neatly fixed her bed without losing precious time, before taking a step towards the living room.

There, she picked the usual butler costume - washed from last night's dirty burial and left off to dry for the night by the fireplace. Clothes folded underneath her arm, she stepped into the small bathroom on the side to wash her face.

She took a good look into the mirror as she started to remove her nightwear.

Shoulder-length black hair rested neatly on her shoulders, untied from its usual ribbons. The color contrasted sharply with the paleness of her skin, matching more the dark corruption that coursed through the left side of her face. A deep teal streak of hair echoed the idle lights that coursed the substance.

Her face was spotless as usual. Naked skin and shifting substance flowed together where they met as if it had always been there.

Two eyes, the right blue, the left a dull gray, glimmered through the glass.

There was irony, she thought, in the way her reflection gazed at her. Master had outlawed mirrors and reflective surfaces at the manor a few weeks in a frenzy before the first signs occurred. She never had a good chance to look herself over while it happened. Yet here and now, when all was done, she couldn't escape it even if she wished to. Her own eyes stared back everywhere she looked.

She didn't mind it, really. The *thing* in the mirror could stare if it wanted to. *"It is unbecoming for a person of high-society to bend the knee at the gaze of others,"* her Lady had once said.

Then again, was she even a person anymore?

The creature in the reflection tilted its head as the sudden thought gave her pause. Those eyes scanned over the way flesh meshed with substance at the shoulder, detached, empty.

A second passed.

It didn't matter, she decided.

Alice took her gaze off the glass to splash water onto her face, washing away doubt for the day. She grabbed her clothes - black pants paired with a white dress shirt, gray tie and black sleeveless vest - and fitted them on as if second skin. She grabbed two pink ribbons and attached strands of hair at both sides of her face, hand hovering for a brief moment over the last one.

It was bigger, more worn than the rest, and carried with it a child's memory.

She took it without much ceremony and tied it at the back of her hair, letting it sit there.

Finally, all that was left were two white gloves. They slid cleanly over both her hands, covering the last of the substance that wasn't on her face.

She looked once again into the mirror.

The butler looked back.

Alice turned away and stepped out of the room, mentally going over her tasks for the day.

She had been standing there for fourteen minutes and twenty-three seconds.

The door stood as a monolith, insurmountable and impossible.

Her hands were folded before her, a feather duster hanging at the belt. She stared at the handle as if it was about to jump to her throat.

She despised this feeling.

She had cleaned the whole shack twice over. Polished the witch's cauldron, reorganized the various ingredients on the shelves, swept the broom through the corridor, watered the potted plants of mystic origins. All that was left was the rooms.

Her room.

This would be the first time she'd step inside since the witch died.

And Alice still couldn't figure out just why she was standing outside her door.

This should have been done a long time ago. She had much work to go over inside— she didn't have the luxury to stand around and do nothing for minutes at a time.

And still. Every time she reached, the patterns swirled under her sleeves. A dull pain coursed through. A deep, confusing feeling of wrongness and frustration took over.

So, she stood and stared.

Alice closed her eyes. She needed to power through this.

She opened them again, determination shining through as she pulled her right hand from her folded position. It moved towards the handle. Slow, yet inexorable. She ignored the angry agony that rushed over half her body, the whispers of offended grief in her ears, the trembling of the fingers, and, inch by inch, she-

KNOCK KNOCK KNOCK

-paused.

Did her ears betray her?

KNOCK KNOCK KNOCK

They didn't. Someone was at the door.

Her fingers froze just an inch away from the door handle. She pulled her hand back as if it had burned her, focusing her attention away.

Alice walked down the corridor, taking the duster off her belt and placing it on a shelf. She stopped at the front door where *someone* was pounding as if trying to knock off the frame. Her left hand found the handle.

She stopped.

No dull pain. No confusing feelings. Just her fingers, tightly wrapped around the doorknob. Resting on the metal as if second nature.

She opened the door.

A man stood before her, frozen mid-action as he was about to knock again. His eyes were wide open, caught off-guard by her sudden appearance.

He was short, a bit chubby, wearing a wide brown coat over a beige sweater and olive-green trousers with suspenders. A pocket watch hung at his side by a chain, stained with the same mud as his large black knee-high boots. The man had an overall classy yet humble look, helped in part by a carefully groomed thick brown moustache contrasting with short unkempt bed-hair. He wore small, round and cracked glasses. The coat had stitches and patches in various places, the watch indicated the wrong time.

That wasn't aristocracy, yet not quite a common laborer either. Alice often saw the type interacting with Master, representatives of communities that bridged social standing with the means at their disposal.

Master used to have a true smile when talking to them.

The man was still reeling in shock as she stood by the open door like a pillar, hands folded in front of her, staring him down.

"... Good day, sir," she greeted with a perfectly flat, neutral tone. "May I help you?"

To his credit, the man was quick to recover. He seemed to gather himself at the sound of her voice and cleared his throat before speaking.

"Good day," he greeted politely. His voice was steady, warm, despite the slight trembling of his closed fists held near his mouth that betrayed nervousness. "Alice, I presume?"

Alice narrowed her eyes, slightly. She felt a tinge of caution under her sleeve. She didn't move.

"You presume right," she answered, flat, a tinge of defensiveness that didn't bleed through her voice. "And who, might I ask, is asking?"

"Ah!" The man startled, "I do apologize! I forget myself." He held an embarrassed smile and shook his head, as if trying to dispel the confusion.

"My name is Ghislain. Ghislain Barnier! I am the mayor of a humble village, just an hour northeast from here. The good witch of these woods is a dear friend of mine, she mentioned your name in her last letter."

Alice relaxed inwardly, just a bit. The man's story held up - she *did* see the witch write a letter a few weeks ago, then send it away by some kind of magic trick just as Alice was about to propose to post it.

"I've been wanting to visit again for far too long but alas," the man continued, oblivious, "my duties have kept me away. And it is only because I come for a request that I was able to free my schedule to come and see her." He shook his head in shame.

She stood silent in the doorway as the moment passed, offering no comfort. An aura of overwhelming anger he couldn't quite place the reason for emanated from her still form.

"A- Anyway," Barnier tried to dispel the awkwardness with another cough. "I- I need to see her. It is a matter quite urgent, you see? Could you please take me to her?"

Alice didn't move a muscle, empty eyes burning into his own. The man seemed to shrivel under her gaze, not knowing what to do as seconds passed. The butler stood unmoving as a wall, a wall he did not understand. He couldn't help but stare at her face: the corpse-like skin tone, the way flesh and matter swirled together, the way her discolored iris almost shone in the darkness of the hallway.

Eventually, Alice moved.

"But of course, good sir." Alice assured, tone and face still perfectly neutral. He took a surprised step back as she exited the swamp house, carefully closing the door behind her. "Please, follow me." The butler didn't spare him a glance as she took off towards the gardens in a surprisingly fast walk. Ghislain stood dumbfounded for a beat before quickly catching up to her, running to do so.

"S- So!" He practically exclaimed as he adjusted to her walking speed. "The witch never told me how you came into her home."

She ignored the conversation hook, continuing to move forward without breaking pace.

"The old geezer never struck me as the type to need servants, you see." He continued, undeterred. "How did you come into her service?"

She still ignored him. The man sighed, taking the hint. He kept going with his poor attempts at conversation anyway, trying out different angles.

"Alice is a pretty name. Where is it from?"

"Where do you live? In the spare room?"

"How is the old woman doing, these days?"

All ended in failures. He cursed inwardly, nervous sweat on his brow.

“... If I may,” he finally ventured, “would you mind telling me what is that… substance on your face? Is it painful?”

That got him some semblance of reaction from the enigmatic woman. Alice paused mid-stride, so sudden that he almost stumbled into her.

She didn’t turn to look at him. Didn’t move a muscle. Ghislain could only see the rough shape of her shoulders, stiff as a tree against a storm. The way her left hand was raised just a bit higher than her right by a barely noticeable margin.

“They called it ‘Sculk’. Sir.” She stated, tone detached, clinical, still.

Then, as if he had imagined the moment, she resumed walking as if nothing happened.

Ghislain was so stunned that he didn’t notice that she hadn’t answered the second question.

They finally stepped into the garden after minutes that felt like ages. The silence was so heavy that Ghislain was now visibly sweating as he followed the otherworldly butler. The man had long abandoned all attempts at conversation after the last slip-up, mulling over a thousand questions he didn’t dare to ask. He didn’t want to make the mysterious woman more hostile to his presence than she already was.

Alice thought it wise on his part.

The garden was a modest thing: exotic swamp plants, carefully trimmed bushes of black roses, mushrooms of every variety growing near the base of a large mangrove tree and, of course, the ‘wart’. A parasitic fungus the witch cultivated that thrived on a soil rich in souls.

Alice paused, watching the light wind brush vines and leaves in the tree. The way the bushes seemed to pulsate with life. The swamp was alive.

The garden breathed.

The mayor neared her, footsteps heavy in the soil, breathing thick. His clothes rustled with every movement, the *‘tic’* of his pocket watch filling the air.

“Magnificent as always,” he whispered as he admired the petals of a rose. “So, where is she?”

Alice put a firm left hand to his shoulder, directing his attention to the center of the garden.

“Here, sir.”

His body stiffened underneath her touch, shoulders locking and eyes widening as he finally understood.

A simple rock stood in front of a patch of freshly turned dirt. A single flower lay on the ground, the same as the black roses he had been admiring.

She could pinpoint the exact moment he knew. He was staring at Her grave.

“H-” he stuttered, shaking. “How?” he asked, breathless.

A second of silence passed. Alice held her left wrist with her right hand, the deep grieving pain overwhelming her senses.

“Sickness, sir Barnier.” She answered flat, not a hint of agony transpiring in her tone. “She fell sick a few weeks ago, and never recovered. She died alone in her bed last night. No family at her side.”

He turned his head to look into her eyes, overwhelming guilt and grief pooling in his gaze. She stared back, eyes slightly narrowed.

“No friends.” She spat.

“But, she had y-” he retorted, words dying on his tongue at the death glare he received.

He stood frozen in shameful silence, a thousand emotions coursing through his face. Alice didn’t bother categorizing them. She turned her gaze back to the grave.

She hated how the substance had a tendency to magnify her emotions, at times. The butler struggled to keep a neutral face as this grieving anger took over half her body. Patterns twisted and spiraled erratically underneath the fabric, forcing her left fist into a closing position.

The man did not speak for a few precious minutes. She didn’t either. They stood side by side, staring at Her grave.

Birds sang in the trees. A distant chorus of frog croaks answered the sudden *plop* of something dropping into swamp water. The rising sun shone in the sky, obscured by a white cloud and a thin, rising ambient mist.

The garden breathed.

“I…” He sighed, breaking the sacred silence. “I’m sorry. I understand.”

She stared at him, emotionless. He didn’t look at her as he spoke, cleaning his glasses while still staring at the grave as if to hide the wetness of his eyes.

“I apologize. I truly do, dear. For everything. I…” He choked, voice thick with emotion. “I should have been there. If- if this is…”

He paused.

She waited.

He cleared his throat with a cough.

“It is my nephew, you see.” He continued without moving his gaze. “Illness has befallen him. The village healer cannot do a thing. I… I came to ask the witch to help him, yet it seems I was too late. She’s gone, and with her, so is her knowledge.”

He turned his head towards the shack, eyes distant.

Then, he frowned.

“Wait.”

He turned back to her, staring now in awe.

“*You…*” He whispered, reverent, desperate.

Alice *almost* took a step back, unsure of the change in tone. Her feet stayed planted in the mud, her ankles refused to move. There was something unnerving in the way he looked at her.

“You served her for months, dear,” his gaze was wide, hopeful for salvation. “She spoke highly of your aid in her brewing efforts in her latest letter. You must know something, please!” He dropped to his knees in the mud, hands clasped together in prayer. “You must help me!”

A moment passed. She stared, silent, at the man at her feet. It felt wrong- **so** wrong. She hated every second of it with every fiber of her being.

Could she even help him? Bring about the miracle he asked of her? Despite all her time with the witch, she didn’t know much about… magic.

She closed her eyes.

It didn’t matter. She would find a way.

Such was her role.

She nodded at the man, body stiff.

“Of course, sir,” she stated. “It is my duty.”

The garden breathed.

As late morning turned to afternoon, a thin fog settled over the swamp lands. By dusk, it had thickened enough to blot out the faint final rays of the sun. By night, it had become impossible to distinguish anything in the darkness.

The swamp had gone to sleep. The croaks of frogs had been replaced by an eerie silence. The sparks of fireflies vanished amongst the smothering mist.

Creatures roamed the dark. The monsters of the night *thrived* under the pale moonlight.

Reanimated decomposing corpses of past adventurers stumbled through the fog, their once brilliant minds overrun with animalistic instincts and insatiable hunger. Their weapons *ground* across the soil behind them as their limbs lacked the rigidness they once had, doomed by a cruel god to leave behind a trail of blood and rot. Spiders the size of bulls emerged from caves and ruined homes, their eight legs clicking rhythmically on stone and soil. Oozing, slimy aberrations of a thousand shapes *slid* across swamp mud and water, propagating a stench as their fluids melted anything organic.

The sounds and grunts of monsters echoed throughout the forest, all searching for their next prey on which to feast.

Alice walked along the main stony road, steps reverberating through the night. She held no lantern (she didn't need any), merely a thin sword at her belt.

She paced without worry, uncaring for the horrors of the night, simply getting to her destination as efficiently as possible. Monsters weren't interested in her anyway- at most, one would take a sniff in her general direction, and turn away. The few desperate enough for an easy meal swiftly found their heads separated from their bodies.

So, she walked through the fog, bottled potion in hand, following the path indicated to her by Mayor Barnier.

The further she went, the sparser the fog became. Monster sounds didn't vanish, but grew progressively quieter. She could now see the grass along the road: she had exited the swamp outright, now crossing barren fields under the stars. The village was in view, surrounded by thin walls of mismatched logs and fences and lit up by an array of torches along its borders. A single guard was manning the gate, a red-haired woman in crude iron armor. She stood rigidly, watching Alice's approach with a stiffness reserved for incoming threats.

"Halt!" She shouted at Alice as she got closer, a hand in the air and the other on her sword's hilt. "Identify yourself! Who-"

Her eyes widened in shock as Alice's face came illuminated by the light of a torch.

"*What* are you?"

“My name is Alice.” She bowed to the guard, her body stiff. “Sir Barnier expects me.”

The woman looked into her eyes, disturbed, evaluating, before sighing and relaxing her stance.

“Shit-” she cursed. “Yeah, sorry, my fault. He told me you’d be coming, ‘just didn’t expect his ‘guest’ to come out of the night like a fricking zombie. Please just… bring a light or something next time, so I know you ain’t trying to eat me.”

“Noted,” Alice nodded seriously.

A beat of silence passed as the woman stared at her with a hint of a frown. Her eyes traced the reflection of torchlight against sculk-skin. She eventually sighed again and crossed her arms, faking casualness by standing against the wall.

“Anyway,” she said, “name’s Emily. Mayor’s place is that way-” she threw a finger over her shoulder, “you can’t miss it, it’s right next to the church.”

Again, Alice nodded a quick thanks, before stepping into the village. She could feel the guard’s lingering gaze but paid no mind to it, turning right at the corner.

She walked through the empty streets lit by torches at the same pace she did on the road, surrounded by monsters engulfed in the darkness of the night. Only now she was surrounded by quiet, the sound of gravel beneath her feet being the only sound resonating through the quaint village.

Yet, only *she* could hear the light snores of the people slumbering in their homes, the hushed whispers of a couple trying to put their crying newborn to sleep, the feather-like steps of a cat stretching on hardwood.

If she just closed her eyes, she’d be able to feel, to… *sense* the quiet peacefulness. Their love for the present, hopes for tomorrow. Their intrigue towards their new visitor, their curiosity for what lay outside the walls. The patterns on her skin would echo their fear of the unknown, their worries for the future, swirling evermore underneath the fabric.

So, she didn’t. She kept her gaze forward, unblinking and unbreathing, marching ever onward through the empty streets.

Eventually, she came into view of the church. It was an old and imposing building of pale dilapidated stone, most likely the oldest edifice for miles. If she had to guess, the whole village was likely built *around* it. Next to it though, was a small, quaint house of modest proportions.

This was the place. She could see a candlelight through the curtains, movement behind every window.

She walked to the porch and knocked once.

There was shuffling inside, frenetic steps and agitated voices she didn't care to decipher.

She waited in front of the door, unmoving. A muffled shout drew closer. She forced her lungs to fill with air again.

The door suddenly opened fast and wide, revealing Ghislain Barnier, somehow looking even more disheveled than this morning.

He hadn't bothered changing clothing or washing away the morning swamp mud off of his trousers. His unkept bed-hair was messier somehow, dirtier than it was before. He didn't have his coat on, only the beige sweater.

"Alice," he half-*barked* through a choked throat. "Y-you came."

She stiffened at his tone - desperate, reverent, like she was holier than the church next door - but nodded anyway, tilting her head with a hint of confusion.

"Of course, sir." She repeated. "It is my duty."

A smile spread across his face as his shoulders uncoiled slightly, as if her mere appearance relieved him of tension. His tired gaze brushed her face, trailing down to her hands and lingering on the bottled potion she held in her left hand.

He froze, his breathing shallow.

"Is… Is it…?" he asked, tentatively.

Alice's grip tightened around the bottleneck.

She had returned to the witch's hut, not long after the Mayor's departure. Fog had started to settle outside, a white mist covering each and every window. Alice had lit the candles, if only out of habit, in the room she had cleaned just a few hours ago.

Truth to be told, she had no idea how to fulfill the man's request. The same illness that took away the witch's life had befallen his nephew. If even she couldn't cure herself, how was Alice supposed to do anything?

She had marched to the empty cauldron, taking off her gloves and rolling up her sleeves. A bucket of distilled water lay next to it. She had emptied its contents into the cauldron without a thought, lighting up a fire underneath, turning towards the bookshelves while waiting for the water to boil.

Her eyes had hovered over the recipe books, deeply unsure about what to do next. She had mimicked every preparation she ever assisted the witch with so far. Normally, the woman would pick a seemingly random book off the shelves (or pretend to be annoyed as Alice did it for her). She would flip through the pages lightning fast, somehow landing on the exact recipe she needed for the day without

fail. She would laugh, happily, as she listed off every ingredient needed for Alice to gather through her home.

She wouldn't anymore.

A familiar ache rose, somehow both intense and numbing. Alice's world darkened, sounds echoed painfully louder, her vision spun. She used her good hand to prop herself up against the table, her left massaging her throbbing temple.

Hushed whispers she couldn't make sense of rose and rose, accompanied by a deep ringing that wrecked her brain. She felt her legs go limp under her, bringing her kneeling on the floor.

The world swirled, sensations loud and confusing twirling on and on and on. She was aware, distantly, of the fact that her eyes were open, gaze moving frantically over the bookshelves without seeing them. The whispers were deafening. It was hell. It was an overwhelming typhoon that she was trapped at the center of. It was-

It stopped.

All pain and sensation vanished in an instant, her eyes fixated on a single tome at the top of the shelf. Its binding black as the night, words she couldn't read embroidered in gold on the side.

Her entire being tugged towards it.

She rose to her feet like a corpse rising from the grave. She grabbed the book. Pulled it from the shelf. Opened it on the desk. She moved the pages until she got to a specific one, words in an undecipherable script written all over as if the author poured a manic episode onto paper.

Somehow, some part of her just… knew.

Alice didn't question it. Instead, she opened a cupboard, grabbing ingredients and preparing to follow its instructions.

"Yes," she responded, voice tight and clipped. "This is your cure, sir."

Ch2 - The Storm

Alice was back in front of the door.

She stood still, hands folded before her chest, staring a murderous glare at the metallic handle. Her temples hurt. A foreign sense of indignation was echoing from her covered half.

This was, admittedly, becoming a problem.

It was only yesterday that she was in this very same position, unable to bring herself to open the Witch's door. Unable to fulfill her duty due to a misguided sense of grief and rebellion from the sculk scouring her skin. Stuck in a place of memories and painfully familiar emotions.

She could feel her fists tighten despite herself. She had to overcome this, to force her way through the pain. Through the rage, the despair. She had a job to do. She-

KNOCK KNOCK KNOCK

-paused.

Wasn't this familiar? A part of her she thought dead mused sarcastically. She uncoiled her fists, annoyed both at the thought and the interruption, as she stepped away from the accursed door.

Alice made her way, again, through the corridor to the shack's entrance. She paused in the entryway, looking into the mirror mounted on the wall. She looked as usual. The reflection held a firm posture in a poised butler outfit, two empty eyes devoid of emotion held her gaze. She glanced at her chest, eerily still and unmoving, and practiced taking a breath in a steady rhythm.

The illusion of normalcy was important to guests, after all.

Confident in passing as 'alive' she reached for the handle (it was cold, mundane, unremarkable) and opened the door.

Sure enough, as expected, there stood Ghislain Barnier.

The man had the exact same appearance he did yesterday, somehow, down to the wrinkle in his coat and the mud stain on his boots. His broken watch dangled uselessly at his side, his cracked glasses sat on his nose with the elegance of a drunkard riding a pig. Yet, there was something different to him.

He wasn't afraid, surprised, nor unsettled as he was last time. There was instead a manic glint of glee in his eyes, a child-like giddiness in his posture. And just as she opened the door, he *lunged* toward her…

…And pulled her into a bear-hug, his shoulders shaking with emotion. Tears wet her costume as he openly wept into her with an immeasurable sense of relief and happiness.

Alice was stiff as a board, eyes slightly widened at the sudden display of emotion. She didn't return the hug, letting the man grab her body like a lifeline for as long as he wanted to.

Lysandre hugged her legs tight, as if she was going to vanish if he faltered even slightly in his grip. The 8 year old boy openly wept in her pants. She let him, softly patting his head with her left hand. She let him hold on to her like a lifeline for as long as he wanted to. The dog was very dear to the young master, after all.

Alice blinked her eyes open, dispelling the memory.

"What happen-"

"*It worked*." The man croaked out, interrupting her. "You- I- I can't believe it still but…"

He pulled away, moving up his arms so he could hold her shoulders in his hands. His face was tear streaked, he smiled warmly as he sniffed snot.

"It *worked*," he insisted. "It worked! I- I don't know *how* you did it, but… It did. We had lost all hope. The doctors said he wasn't going to survive the night. He was-"

He choked, voice thick with emotion. The man seemed to need a second to gather himself. Alice used it to pull out of his grip, considering her tear-stained jacket with resignation. Then, she sighed inwardly as she angled her body towards the door.

"Would you like to come inside, sir ?" She asked, as proper etiquette demanded of her.

"I- thank you. I would very much like to."

She nodded wordlessly as she beckoned him into her home, taking his coat and hanging it next to the door, not sparing a glance at her reflection. Then, she guided him to the kitchen - ignoring his shamed *sniffs* - which was, coincidentally, also the brewing room. She sat him at the table, handing him a box of tissues as she poured him a glass of water.

Only then, did he seem to calm down. His eyes wandered all over the room with curiosity as he spoke.

"A-after you left last night, we gave him your medicine." His voice still wavered and cracked, but it was steadier than before. "I- I had never seen him so… exhausted. He drifted off to sleep. I… I was sure he was gone. That his heart stopped. That the potion was all for naught. And, and then…"

He looked at her, eyes distant filled with wonder and fondness.

“*He cried*. He- he had been emotionless, lifeless, this whole week. Fighting off the disease took everything he had. And- and he *cried*. So full of life, my *boy*-” his voice cracked.

Barnier looked about to cry again himself. He lifted off his glasses with one hand, wiping away tears with the other.

“The-” he restarted, voice wobbly. “The doctor came back again this morning. He said he had never seen anything like it. That he’s made a full recovery. That- that my *boy* is healthy.”

He looked into her eyes with devastating kindness. Alice could see her form reflected in his spectacles, the left cracked glass distorting her image.

“*Thank you*,” he declared, “Lady Alice. You saved him. You saved my boy.”

She *hated* the title.

She forced herself to stay still and uncoiled her fists, forgetting to breathe.

“I- I owe you a lifelong debt. If it were not for you, I’d be burying him right now. Whatever you want, whatever you need, I shall do my best to provide it to you. You are a welcomed member of our community now, the guards will know. Come at any time.”

A beat of silence passed as Alice met his gaze, unnerved and wary.

She would not take him up on his offer, she decided. After all, it wasn’t likely she’d ever need a thing from him or his village.

“Noted.” She nodded, anyway, ignoring the pang in her left ribcage as the mayor smiled at her warmly.

In the end, the man stayed for about half an hour more before finally heading back out, returning to his family. He still spoke amicably on his way out, almost as if stalling for time, reaching for her sympathy before making the trek back home. He had hugged her one last time at the doorstep before setting off.

She had stayed two minutes longer than was needed at the doorway, watching his distant figure getting swallowed by the swamp. As sympathetic as the man was, his unrelenting… *humanity* was grating, to say the least.

Yet not unwelcome, some part of her pondered.

How strange.

Her gaze dropped to her black jacket, still freshly tainted with tears. She had already cleaned the mayor's snot off of it.

Alice looked to the skies. No clouds in sight this morning.

She took off the jacket, dressed only in white sleeved shirt and gray tie, and hung it up to dry on a tree branch next to the shack. Satisfied, she headed back inside.

She ignored her reflection in the entrance mirror - *how wrong it was* - and walked back into the brewing room, where the mayor had left behind a pile of used tissues and an empty glass. She set to work, grabbing a wet sponge and wiping the table clean.

As she did so, she glanced at the desk in the corner next to the now empty cauldron. Where she had brewed the potion that saved the child's life, somehow. Where she had read impossible words from one of the Witch's books.

She stopped dead in her tracks.

Where was it? She could swear she had left it open on the desk yesterday. The book. That eerie black grimoire adorned with gold that called to her, that-

What book? **It** thought.

There never was any book? **It** echoed.

What did you read, then? **It** stuttered, confused.

Was any of this real? **It** wondered.

CRACK

Her shoulders flinched at the sudden sound of thunder. She broke out of her reverie to find the skies outside dark as night, the flash of sparse lightning casting shadows out of trees and undead into the unlit room. The sponge in her hand was dry.

Her eyes unfocused. Her throat tightened. Her head throbbed with pain.

She didn't know how much time had passed.

She all but collapsed on the table, holding herself up with her left hand.

She didn't know how much time had passed.

No light entered the room in between lightning flashes and yet, she could see clear as day. There wasn't a black book. There was *never* any book.

She felt a foreign exhaustion she could not recognize. Her head was cacophony. Her ears numb, overwhelmed. Her breathing was labored. It didn't make sense. She didn't even need to breathe.

The world swirled around. She let it happen, closing her eyes and willing her long-dead lungs back in control. She counted the seconds.

At fifty-seven, something whispered. *'Your jacket.'* it alarmed her, gentle.

Alice opened back her eyes and looked outside the window. It was pouring.

She nodded, thankful, and marched out, grabbing an umbrella by the door while pointedly ignoring the mirror. She stepped onto the grass, carefully avoiding mud puddles and overflowing swamp water as she looked for the piece of clothing in the storm.

The morning sun, a distant memory of ten minutes ago, had long since set over the swamp. The moon ruled over the skies while hidden by dark clouds, its presence only evident by the stench and grunts of creatures of the night roaming around. Just as last night, most took a sniff in her general direction and turned away with disgust.

Alice felt disoriented in the storm. Not because of the darkness, but because blinding bursts of light made her head pound with pain. Not because of the wailing rain, but because the constant howling wind overwhelmed her hearing. She kept marching on, finally having the jacket in sight, hanging on a tree branch.

Something stood in front of her.

A corpse.

The creature was long dead, its body in an advanced state of decomposition that left only bones and tendons. Its soulless eyes looked at her with famine and concerning wariness. Its jaw no longer had the muscles to close, hanging wide open and producing guttural sounds. Its neck couldn't hold its head upright, balancing it one side to another with every step it made. Its arms lay uselessly at its sides, stained with dry blood and dirt.

She held the creature's gaze.

It held hers.

Lightning burnt the skies bright.

She closed her eyes briefly, blinded.

The creature lunged.

She couldn't react, stunned by the light as it put all its weight on her shoulders and pushed her to the ground, its own mass bringing it down with her. It pounced, its jaw searching for her throat while its rotted limbs did everything she could to keep her pinned in the mud.

Unfortunately for the creature, it didn't have the muscles to do so.

As soon as Alice regained her senses she put her left arm out, holding the creature at length as its spit spilled over her face and suit while its mouth chattered again and again like a chomping toy. Her right hand found her umbrella through the mud and grabbed its handle.

As soon as she held it steady she pressed the button that triggered its closing mechanism, and *swung* it like a bat over the corpse's head. It stayed attached to its torso and its whole body rolled over next to her, writhing in pain.

She pressed a knee over its chest, holding it in place as it thrashed against her. She dropped the umbrella and watched its face.

It looked at her with unnatural hatred.

She looked back with detached indifference.

It had tried to kill her.

Her left hand found the creature's throat and, before she even noticed, *squeezed*.

It thrashed harder against the pressure, desperate and in agony. The bones *cracked* under her touch. She leaned in, using her other hand to crush harder.

It was right. It was retribution. It was judgement.

The undead writhed and squirmed and thrashed and flailed, producing a cacophony of sounds one could mistake for pleas to the living.

She held.

She held until the bones felt like dust in her hand.

She held until the roaring whispers in her ears subsided.

She held until its struggling stopped.

And then, it did.

Alice got back up, and turned back towards her jacket.

The wind was still howling. The rain was still pouring. She was covered in mud, grime and dust. Her entire butler outfit was drenched.

She paused her step when passing by the path leading to the garden. She listened.

Even now, it breathed.

Something in her settled. She didn't notice her hands were shaking until they didn't. Didn't notice she still held a bone until she dropped it. Finally, she could see her prize.

Her butler's jacket. Hanging by the tree, ironically looking cleaner than the rest of her outfit.

She reached for it and-

A growl stopped her.

Her eyes turned to the source, at the base of the tree.

Here, in the shadows, was a young wolf curled up on itself. It eyed her with defiance and fear, its white fur covered in grime and blood.

"I am not in the mood, little one." She declared, pulling back with wide gestures so as not to aggravate it.

The wolf did not react, still eyeing her with suspicion and a hint of fear. Taking a step back, she remarked that there were various marks across its coat, evidence of fighting, or maybe abuse. It was collared but didn't have a tag.

It uncurled and growled harder, noticeably not resting its front-right leg on the ground.

She walked into the manor, the dog limping at her side.

"Iver!" Someone called from the top of the stairs. "You- you're here!"

The young master barreled down the steps with an energy that didn't match his sickness, pulling the massive dog in a tight hug.

"You- you- thank you, thank you Alice!" He buried his hands in its fur while the dog playfully licked tears off his face. "How- Why-"

"Iver had fallen into the empty well, Lysandre." She comforted the boy despite her detached tone, patting his head. "And because I know he is very dear to you. You were heartbroken that you couldn't find him, so I did."

Lysandre watched her in awe. It settled something warm inside her.

"Besides, I do have a thing for dogs." She admitted with a neutral look on her face, scratching Iver's head. The dog's tail wagged happily.

Alice watched the juvenile canine growling before her. Scared, confused, shivering in the rain with blood on its tail.

She crouched, slow, and grabbed the monster's bone she had discarded earlier. She held it towards the wolf using her left hand, and watched its whole demeanor shift.

It stopped growling, now radiating hunger and curiosity.

It took a step forward tentatively.

It sniffed once.

Twice.

Then, slowly, it sat next to her hand and grabbed the bone.

She patted its head gently, it leaned into her touch.

Something warm buzzed inside.

Content, Alice got back up and finally, after everything, grabbed her jacket.

She turned back towards the shack, and headed back inside. The puppy limped beside her towards the entrance. She slowed down to match its pace and, as she opened the door, she let it enter first.